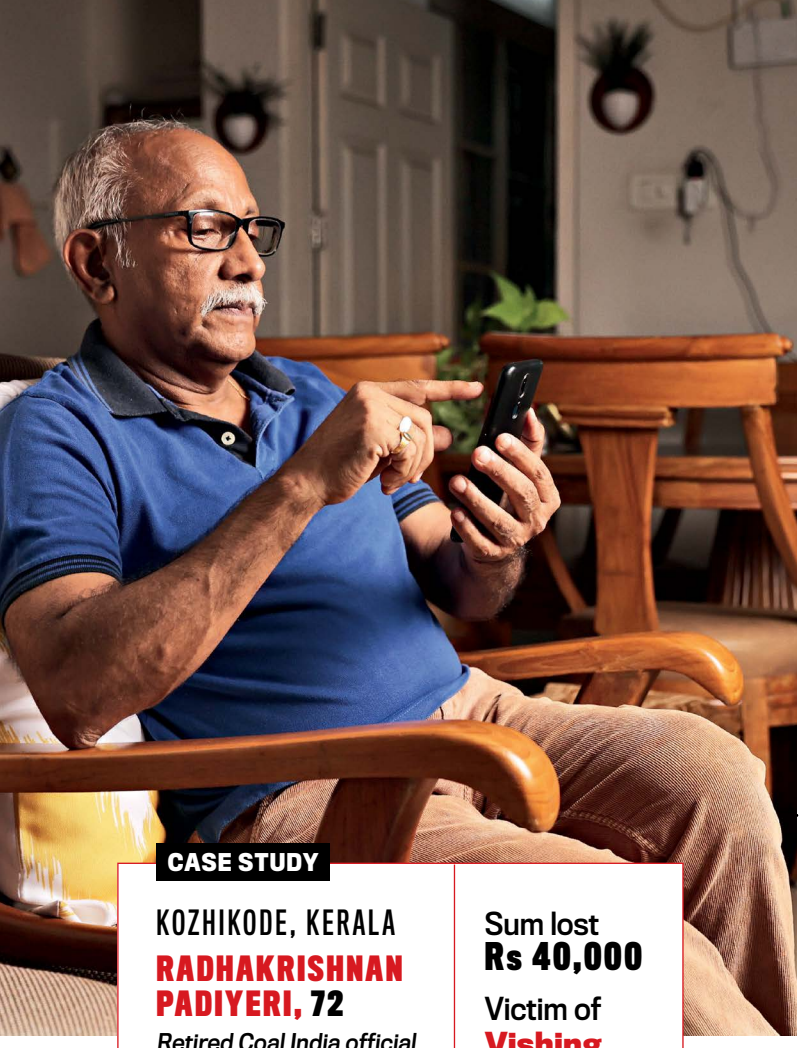


SUJITH KARAD

CASE STUDY

KOZHIKODE, KERALA

RADHAKRISHNAN PADIYERI, 72

Retired Coal India official

Sum lost
Rs 40,000

Victim of
Vishing

A Passing Acquaintance

It was 5.45 am on July 9 when Padiyeri got a missed call from an unknown number. When he returned the call an hour later, the man at the other end introduced himself as an old colleague with whom Padiyeri had not spoken to for months. Soon, they switched to a WhatsApp video call, as Padiyeri's 'colleague' said he was at the Dubai airport. The septuagenarian recalls it was a very bright video, showing just his former colleague's face. Having done his homework, the conman even asked after Padiyeri's children and other colleagues to establish trust. And then came the clincher. The conman asked Padiyeri if he could transfer Rs 40,000 to an account to pay for a medical emergency in Mumbai since he himself was away. Little realising that he was being conned, Padiyeri did as he was asked. Police investigation revealed that the money was received in Gujarat and then sent to an account in Mumbai. Padiyeri got his own account frozen. The conman's account had received eight more payments of Rs 40,000 the same day. Padiyeri is now waiting for a refund. ■

-Jeemon Jacob

one is immune to their machinations—DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran lost Rs 99,999 on October 8, when money from his Axis Bank savings account was transferred via net banking, "bypassing all normal safety protocol", as he said in a post on X (formerly Twitter). On the same day, Bollywood actor Aftab Shivdasani lost Rs 1.5 lakh after he entered his bank details on a link sent from an unknown number saying his account would be suspended if he did not update his KYC details. Back in 2021, Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal's daughter Harshita was defrauded of Rs 34,000 while trying to sell a sofa on a reselling portal. The same year, Bollywood actor Shabana Azmi and comedian Johnny Lever fell for a fake wine-selling portal.

WHY CYBERCRIME IS RISING

What explains this exponential rise in cybercrime? The 'ease of doing business', for one. You don't require much capital, only a smartphone, a pre-activated SIM card and a relatively stable internet connection to get going. Some of India's very advantages are now proving to be liabilities—the growing internet penetration, cheap rates of data and telephony and low-cost smartphones, ensuring everyone has a cellphone and some amount of access to the internet. Today, 840 million Indians have a digital presence, internet connections have increased by 250 per cent over the past nine years and the cost per GB of data has come down by 96 per cent. The Jan Dhan Yojana has seen the opening of 500 million new bank accounts. Another enabler has been the much-touted rise in digital payments—over 10 billion just in August 2023, according to Manish Agrawal, executive vice-president, and head, credit intelligence and control, HDFC Bank, with India having a 46 per cent share of the global figure, per government estimates.

The rising human dependence on technology, which now pervades every aspect of life, be it education or entertainment, travel or hospitality, banking or shopping, has given conmen an unlimited field to practise their craft in. The Covid-19 pandemic only accelerated that shift. Not only did working individuals go WFH, crime too went online. Bit by bit, cyber crooks infiltrated the entire universe, from social networking platforms such as Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, X and LinkedIn, to voice and video chat forums such as WhatsApp and Telegram, to e-commerce portals, bank websites, online payment apps and e-wallets...in short, every possible internet stopover that forms a part of an individual's daily regimen today.